CHARTERED INSTITUTE OF STATISTICIANS OF NIGERIA (CISON)

3rd International Conference and Golden Jubilee: From Legacy to Leadership

Rapporteur's Report

Salient points from the opening ceremony: goodwill messages, official address and keynote

Item	Detail
Session	Opening ceremony, Day One (15 October 2026)
Speakers covered	Ghana Statistical Association; World Bank Group; Nigeria Revenue Service; Honourable Minister of Budget and Economic Planning (read by the Statistician-General); Statistician-General of the Federation and CEO, NBS; Keynote speaker; declaration of opening on behalf of the Vice President
Submitted by	Etebom Ndarake Ekott
Purpose	To give the Communique Committee a distilled set of key messages, commitments and candidate recommendations

1. Headline Messages

Across the six addresses, six messages recurred.

1. **Evidence must drive decisions.** Budgets, revenue plans, poverty targets and the siting of schools and clinics all rest on statistics. Weak data produces guesswork; sound data allows confident planning and accountability (Minister, NRS, World Bank).
2. **Trust is the profession's core asset.** Public confidence depends on independence of professional judgment, transparent methods, openly explained revisions and quality accountability (Statistician-General, Keynote, Minister).
3. **Professional standards must rise.** The Chartered Statistician title should become a mark of quality, backed by certification examinations from 2027 and a national accreditation pathway (Minister, Statistician-General).
4. **Innovation must be shaped by statisticians.** Big data, AI, geospatial and administrative data are changing practice. Nigeria should shape, not merely adopt, these tools, with privacy, sound methods and human accountability kept central (all speakers).
5. **Statistical literacy is a national gap.** Citizens, legislators, executives and the media need to read data correctly, including statistics taught at secondary school level (Minister, Statistician-General, Keynote).
6. **The next generation is the legacy.** Mentorship, employer-linked training, career paths into public service and opportunities for women and underserved communities (Minister, Keynote, GSA).

2. Salient Points by Theme

2.1 Evidence for policy and public accountability

- Every budget decision, from revenue projection to growth assumptions and poverty targets, is built on numbers (Minister).
- Revenue administration depends on statistics to assess potential, identify compliance gaps and test whether interventions work. "A nation's ability to mobilize its resources begins with its ability to understand them" (NRS).
- Late statistics describe yesterday's problem while government decides tomorrow's; timeliness is a trust issue (Keynote).
- Data needs flagged as priority: informal economy, jobs and incomes, agriculture and food security, climate risk, welfare of women, youth and vulnerable groups, and state and local government data (Minister). Agricultural data on yields, land, livestock, storage losses and prices is critical because food security, rural livelihoods and inflation are linked (Keynote).

2.2 Professional standards and the Chartered Statistician title

- Legal recognition now allows the title to become a mark of quality in government, business and academia (Minister).
- Certification examinations are planned for 2027; the charter should stand for competence, ethics and professional independence (Minister).
- The NBS invited CISON to jointly set the federal standard and accreditation pathway for statisticians in the national statistical system (Statistician-General).

2.3 Innovation, big data and AI

- Big data is the ability to combine diverse, fast-generated datasets to extract insights conventional methods miss; AI accelerates this (Keynote).
- Practical illustrations: anticipating food shortages from prices, weather and satellite data; early outbreak detection from surveillance and stock data; siting classrooms, clinics and roads from population-movement data (Keynote).
- Data must move from the back office to the boardroom and shape investment, budgeting and risk decisions, not decorate reports afterwards (Keynote).
- Cautions: AI cannot manufacture truth from unreliable data; poor data produces sophisticated errors at speed; privacy, cybersecurity, confidentiality and human accountability must stay central (Keynote, Minister).
- Singapore's whole-of-government data model was offered as a principle to adapt (interoperable data, shared standards, evidence-driven decisions), not copy wholesale (Keynote).
- The World Bank called for a system that draws on surveys, censuses, administrative records, geospatial information and new digital sources (World Bank).

2.3a Trust, independence and transparency

- "A figure is only as credible as the people who stand behind it." Explaining methods, admitting limits and openly correcting revisions builds confidence (Statistician-General).

- Statistical institutions must be independent in professional judgment, transparent in method and accountable for output quality; unexplained discrepancies erode trust (Keynote).

2.4 Strengthening the national statistical system

- Recent achievements: GDP rebased to 2019; CPI revised; first GDP estimates for all states and the FCT; a ward-level enumeration exercise; modernised, geospatial-enabled data collection; progress on integrating administrative records (Minister, Statistician-General).
- The third National Strategy for the Development of Statistics (NSDS3) focuses on technology and modernisation, adequate financing and applied statistics (Statistician-General).
- A review of the Statistics Act is under way so the legal framework fits a modern system (Statistician-General).
- Challenges named candidly: inadequate financing for data production; some public bodies not documenting or sharing data; incomplete harmonisation across producers; low statistical literacy (Statistician-General). Censuses, price collection and modern systems need sustained investment (Minister).

2.5 Statistical literacy and public voice

- CISON is expected to explain misunderstood figures, engage when methods are questioned, and speak in classrooms, boardrooms and the media as "the face, the voice and the advocacy" of the wider statistical system (Statistician-General).
- Collaboration with NBS, universities and the media to raise literacy, including introducing statistics at secondary school level (Minister).
- Help Nigerians distinguish evidence from speculation, correlation from causation, and statistical significance from practical importance (Keynote).

2.6 The next generation

- Link training to employer needs, offer mentorship from experienced members, and open career paths into public service (Minister).
- Mentor young statisticians, expand opportunities for women and underserved communities, and attract the brightest university talent (Keynote).
- Align university curricula with the skills official statistics now demand, spanning sampling, estimation and national accounts alongside AI, machine learning and geospatial tools (Statistician-General).

3. Commitments and Offers Made

The following were stated on the floor and may be worth recording in the communique as partnership commitments.

Party	Commitment or offer
NBS (Statistician-General)	Open consultation on methods; published release calendars; clear notes on revisions and limitations; a standing partnership with CISON on training and standards; opening the NBS technical forum to CISON members so the profession is consulted before decisions are made.
Ministry of Budget and Economic Planning	Continued support for the NBS, State Bureaus of Statistics and the wider national statistical system; acknowledgement that sustained investment is needed.
World Bank Group	Continued support for strengthening Nigeria's statistical system so that high-quality data improves policy and lives.
Ghana Statistical Association	Deeper cooperation with CISON on professional excellence, capacity development and ethical practice across Africa.
Nigeria Revenue Service	Welcomed collaboration to strengthen capability and apply research to Nigeria's fiscal priorities.

Expectations placed on CISON

- Co-develop the federal standard and accreditation pathway; deliver the 2027 certification examinations.
- Align university curricula with official statistics needs.
- Advocate for data sharing, timely data provision and data protection.
- Build public statistical literacy and act as a dependable, independent source of professional advice on national processes (Keynote).
- Mentor young professionals and promote common standards across federal and state levels.

4. Proposed Recommendations

1. **Professional standards.** CISON, working with the NBS and relevant authorities, should finalise the national accreditation pathway and commence certification examinations for Chartered Statisticians in 2027.
2. **Independence and transparency.** Statistical agencies should be safeguarded in their professional independence, publish release calendars and methodology notes, and explain revisions openly.
3. **Legal and institutional framework.** The review of the Statistics Act should be concluded promptly, taking account of the Institute's charter and professional standards.
4. **Financing.** Government and development partners should provide adequate and sustained funding for censuses, surveys, price collection and modern data systems, in line with NSDS3.
5. **Data sharing and harmonisation.** MDAs and sub-national bodies should document and share administrative data, adopt common standards and strengthen the integrated statistical system, with strong privacy and cybersecurity safeguards.
6. **Innovation.** Members should build capacity in big data, AI, machine learning and geospatial methods, with statisticians taking an active role in shaping how these tools are applied in the public and private sectors.
7. **Sub-national and priority data.** Strengthen state and local government statistics, and prioritise data on the informal economy, jobs and incomes, agriculture and food security, climate risk and vulnerable groups.
8. **Statistical literacy.** CISON, NBS, universities and the media should expand public statistical literacy, including the introduction of statistics at secondary school level.
9. **Education and skills.** Universities should align curricula with the skills demanded by official statistics and industry, and employers should partner with CISON on training.
10. **Next generation.** Establish structured mentorship, internship and public-service career pathways, with deliberate opportunities for women and underserved communities.
11. **Partnerships.** Take up the NBS offer of access to its technical forum; deepen collaboration with the NRS, the World Bank, the Ghana Statistical Association and other African statistical bodies.
12. **Data in decision-making.** Public and private sector leaders should embed statistical insight in budgeting, investment and risk management, and ensure timely data release.